DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Does God Watch Each Person but Not Each Animal?

Derech Hashem 2:1:1-2:2:2

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 1, paragraphs 1-3, and Chapter 2, paragraphs 1-2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Tuesday 20 April 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: two kinds of providence

This was the week's second session, given on Tuesday in place of Thursday. The day before, the Rabbi had reviewed all of Part 1 and introduced Part 2 on hashgahah.

He repeated the distinction. Hashgahah kelalit, general providence, applies to everything in the universe except human beings. It is not specific: Hashem does not attend to this lion or that sheep, only to the species. If England needs a million sheep for humanity's purpose, Hashem ensures there are a million sheep. When a fox kills one, another takes its place. He remembered watching wildlife films with his father, seeing a lion pounce, and asking where Hashem was for those creatures. "There's no hashgahah. That's fine. The world is random in that sense."

Human beings, in most instances, have hashgahah peratit, individual providence. "It's not that you are just one human being among seven billion... every human being is here for a reason."

Paragraph 1: species and their purpose

All parts of the universe were created only for the ultimate purpose of creation, which is for the sake of humanity. So they exist only as long as they are beneficial to that purpose, and Hashem watches over each species to ensure it is still relevant.

This answers the question raised the day before about extinct species such as the dinosaurs. There is providence over the species: millions of years ago they were needed, and now they no longer serve humanity's purpose, so they no longer exist. What purpose they served, "I can't tell you."

A participant suggested the dinosaurs were created to become our oil reserves. The Rabbi said we cannot rule it out, but we cannot say it definitively either: "We need humility as well." We have no right to say Hashem did this because of that; we accept that what He does is purposeful.

Paragraph 2: the whole system

As explained at the end of Part 1, every creature originates in the kohot, the forces above, and every physical detail is the result of what comes from those forces. There is nothing physical without a source above. Hashem's providence covers the whole system: not only the physical creature, but its kohot and the angels that bring the forces down. The chain runs from Hashem to the angels, to the kohot, to the physical world, and He watches over all of it to keep it relevant to humanity's goal.

Paragraph 3: why human beings are different

Humanity is the only species with the ability to choose between good and bad. Other creatures are passive: they rely on the forces coming down to them, and their instincts are "part of their DNA." Human beings are also active. When we control ourselves for the good, or fail to for the bad, we have an effect upward.

So the providence over humans must differ. If we were passive like animals, general providence over the human species would be enough. But because each person's actions change the world, Hashem must watch the details of every individual's deeds, to repay each one according to his ways, with the requisite reward or consequence. "It's not that God wants to take a break... There's no need to do so" for animals, who have no choice. "Animals are means to an end... Human beings are an end in themselves."

A participant noted the phrase "individual" as a phenomenal idea: every single person can influence the world. The Rabbi agreed, but noted that the book will show it is not quite so for everyone: some people become so animalistic and material that they are left to chance, which can explain why the wicked sometimes prosper.

Noah's ark. A participant suggested that at the Flood, Hashem made a kind of stocktake, saving only the species He wanted to continue. The Rabbi agreed that was a clear-out, "assuming there was a global flood," and left the further questions for another time.

Chapter 2: the plan for humanity

The Rabbi gave an overview. Chapter 1 is a general introduction. Chapters 2 and 3 belong together and give the details of providence over human beings. Chapter 4 will deal with the difference between Jews and non-Jews.

Paragraph 1. As always, the Ramhal begins by reviewing. The purpose of creating humanity is to reach the true good, cleaving to Hashem in the World to Come. Everything a person goes through ends in that final rest and reward. In this world he is bound by the laws of nature, which is the right way for him to reach his goal, and Hashem arranged the whole universe as preparation for the ultimate world. As the Mishnah in Avot says, this world is a corridor.

Paragraph 2. This preparation works on two levels, a point the Rabbi said "explains so many things":

1. Individual: each person attaining his or her own perfection.
2. General: humanity as a whole being prepared.

Because humanity was created with choice, nothing prevents some from going wholly towards good and others wholly towards bad. But in the end, according to Hashem's plan, the bad must be pushed away and the good gathered into one community, and that community will merit the World to Come. So besides individual providence on each of us, there is a general providence over where humanity as a whole is going. Some individuals may fall by the wayside, and perhaps only an elite will make it, but humanity as a whole must evolve and reach its perfection.

A participant asked whether the teaching that the world will be destroyed for a thousand years implies that everyone is evil. The Rabbi explained that it does not: just as even the greatest saddik must die, the world must go through destruction. Those who were perfected form the community that inherits the World to Come.

Summary

- General providence watches over each species, keeping it as long as it serves humanity's purpose; extinct species no longer do.
- Hashem's providence covers the whole chain: the creature, its forces above and the angels.
- Human beings, unlike animals, are active and affect the world, so each person receives individual providence over every deed.
- The preparation for the World to Come works on two levels: each individual's perfection, and humanity as a whole.
- In the end the good will be gathered into one community and the bad pushed away.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/5yNNSHtDkaA · More shiurim: rabbikada.com